

Omnidirectional antenna

This is like a dipole antenna because it radiates its signal 360 degrees horizontally; however, its signal is flatter than a dipole's, allowing for higher gain.

Packet

While it may seem as though you send or receive a continuous stream of data every time you use the Internet, actually, it's more efficient to break up the transmission into pieces called packets. These packets contain information about which computer sent the data and where the data is going. If a packet runs into a problem during its trip, it can attempt to find another route. When all the packets reach where they're going, the recipient computer puts them together again. Modems generally send packets of around 64 characters along with some extras for error checking. When downloading files using a protocol such as Xmodem, however, the packets are larger. And when using Internet protocols such as TCP/IP, the packets are larger still—around 1,500 characters.

PAN

Personal Area Network. A PAN is distinct from a LAN because it's a casual, close-proximity network where connections are made on the fly and temporarily. Meeting attendees, for example, can connect their Bluetooth-enabled notebook computers to share data across a conference room table, but they break the connection once the meeting is over. See also WPAN.

PC Card

A credit card-size peripheral that plugs into a special slot on portable computers (and some desktop models). The card may add RAM, a modem or network adapters, a hard drive, or another device. These PC Cards conform to several standards set by the Personal Computer Memory Card International Association (PCMCIA), and were originally called PCMCIA Cards.

The original Type I PC Card is 3.3 mm thick, a format used mainly to add RAM. Type II cards are thicker—5mm—and often